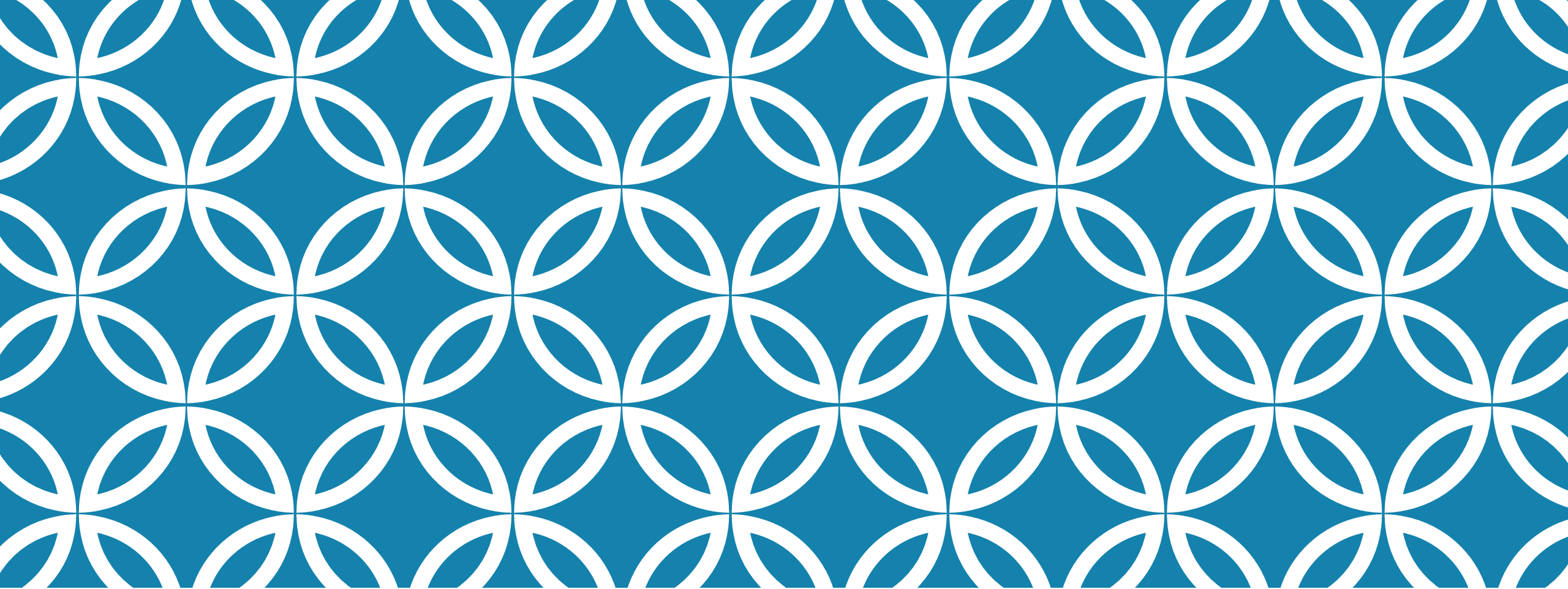




ORGANISATIONAL COMMUNICATION: HOFSTEDE'S CULTURAL DIMENSIONS

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LAST CLASS

- Responding to conflict
- Defining organisations
- Features of organisational communication
- Conveying organisational culture



LEARNING OUTCOMES

1. To understand what is meant by cultural dimensions.
2. To evaluate Hofstede's cultural dimensions.





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CULTURAL DIMENSIONS

A culture is not a random collection of ideas, beliefs, values and customs. Rather, it is a coherent system of understandings, traditions, values, communication practices and ways of living.

It is the collective programming of the mind that distinguishes the members of one group of people from another

Cultures vary on 6 dimensions: Geert Hofstede (1980, 1991, 2001, Hofstede et al., 2010)

Surveyed IBM employees across a range of countries. Found clear differences among IBM employees in different cultures

HOFSTEDE'S CULTURAL DIMENSIONS

Derived four conceptual dimensions on which national cultures display significant differences

1. Individualism/Collectivism
2. Power Distance
3. Masculinity/Femininity
4. Uncertainty Avoidance

Two dimensions were later added:

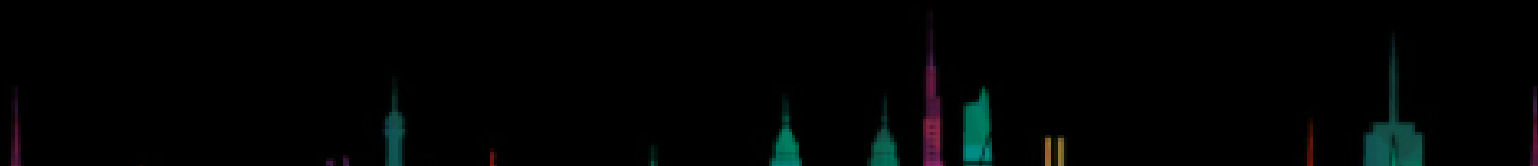
5. Long Term Orientation vs Short Term Orientation
6. Indulgence Versus Restraint

Each dimension is a continuum, and countries score high to low



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1. INDIVIDUALISM/COLLECTIVISM

The degree to which personal needs are valued over the needs of the group
(Hofstede, 1980; 2001)

The high side of this dimension, called Individualism, can be defined as a **preference for a loosely-knit social framework**

Its opposite, Collectivism, represents a preference for **a tightly-knit framework in society** in which individuals can expect their relatives or members of a particular ingroup to look after them in exchange for unquestioning loyalty.

Independence vs. interdependence (Xiao, 2021)

In individualistic cultures, self-definition is based on individual autonomy and separation from others and priority is given to the individual's goals and preferences

In collectivistic cultures, the self is defined primarily based on social embeddedness and interdependence with others ... priority is placed on the needs, norms, and goals of one's group or collective

COLLECTIVIST SOCIETIES VERSUS INDIVIDUALIST SOCIETIES

Collectivist Societies

- “We” identity
- Competition between “tribes”
- Relations before task
- High-context communication
- In-group harmony must be maintained

Individualist societies

- “I” identity
- Competition between individuals
- Task before relations
- Low-context communication
- Confrontations can be healthy

Brazil ×

Ireland ×

Netherlands ×

United Kingdom ×



THE CULTURAL DIMENSION OF INDIVIDUALISM/COLLECTIVISM REFERS TO:

1. The degree of comfort one has with ambiguous or risky situations, versus situations in which the outcome is assured



20%



2. The degree to which personal needs are valued over the needs of the group.



80%

3. The amount of perceived power differential between authority figures and subordinates.

0%

2. POWER DISTANCE INDEX

The amount of perceived power differential between authority figures & subordinates (Hofstede, 1980; 2001)

Refers to the extent to which a society and its individuals **tolerate an unequal distribution of power**

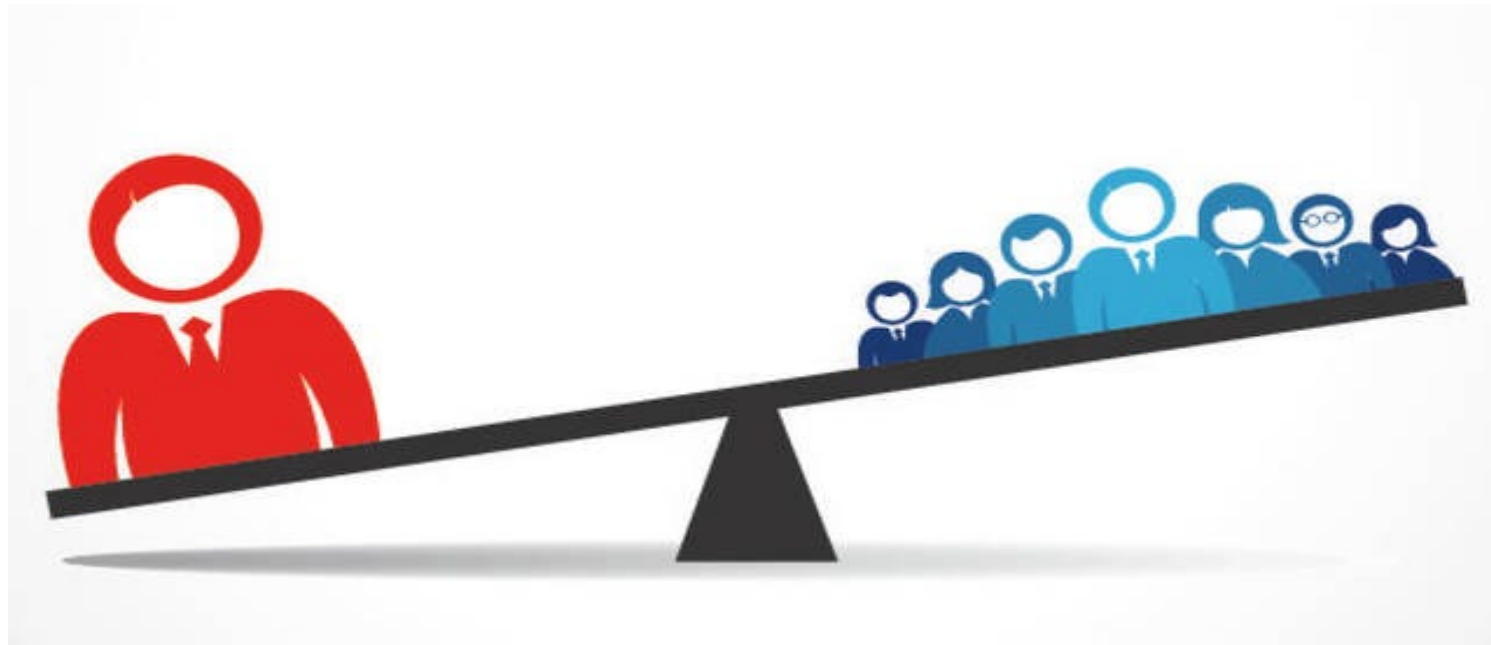
Transferred to children by parents and other elders

India – power often inherited versus New Zealand, Norway

The fundamental issue here is how a society handles inequalities among people.

People in societies exhibiting a large degree of Power Distance accept a hierarchical order

In societies with low Power Distance, people strive to equalise the distribution of power



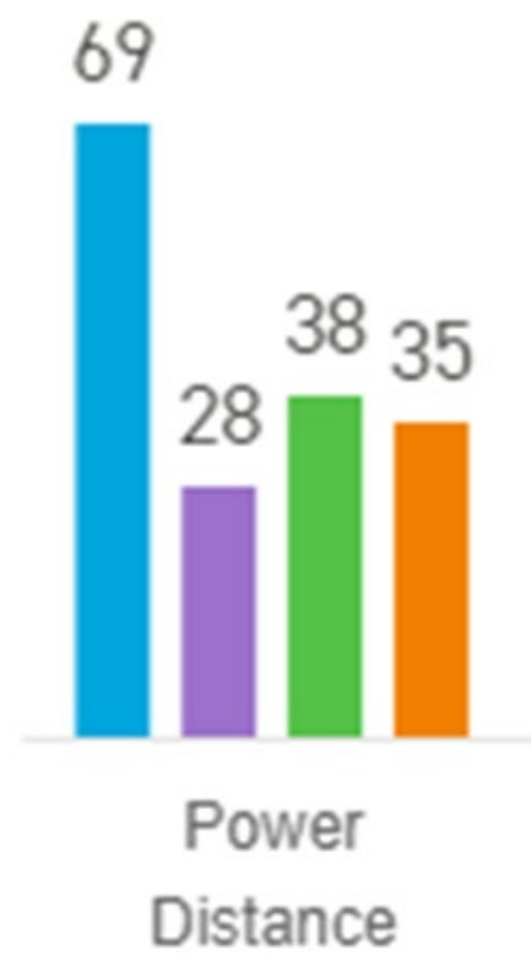
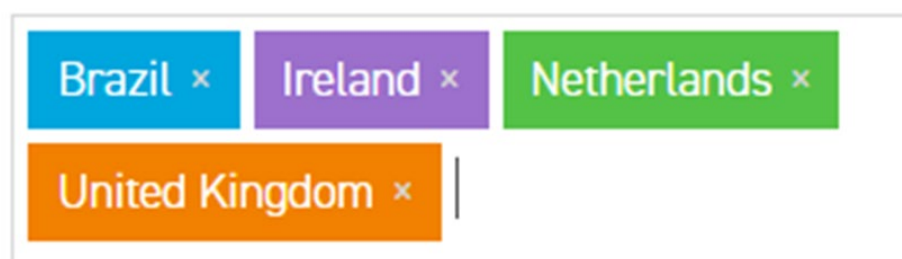
LARGE POWER DISTANCE SOCIETIES VERSUS SMALL POWER DISTANCE SOCIETIES

Large Power Distance Societies

- Inequality is normal
- Superiors are superior beings
- Children should learn respect as a key virtue
- Centralization
- Subordinates expect to be told

Small Power Distance Societies

- Inequality is wrong
- Hierarchy is for practical purposes
- Children should learn to be independent
- Decentralization
- Subordinates expect to be consulted



LARGE POWER DISTANCE SOCIETIES FEATURE ...

1. Decentralisation of power



9.09%



2. Centralisation of power



90.91%

3. MASCULINITY VERSUS FEMININITY

Refers to tough values such as competition & achievement, versus tender values such as interpersonal relationships & care for others (Hofstede, 1980; 2001)

Sometimes referred to as “quality of life versus quantity of life” (Campbell, Converse, & Rogers, 1976; Diener, 1984)

In the business context Masculinity versus Femininity is sometimes also referred to as **“tough versus tender” cultures**.

The Masculinity side of this dimension represents a **preference in society for achievement, heroism, assertiveness, and material rewards for success**.

Its opposite, Femininity, stands for a preference for **cooperation, modesty, caring for the weak and quality of life**.

FEMININE SOCIETIES VERSUS MASCULINE SOCIETIES

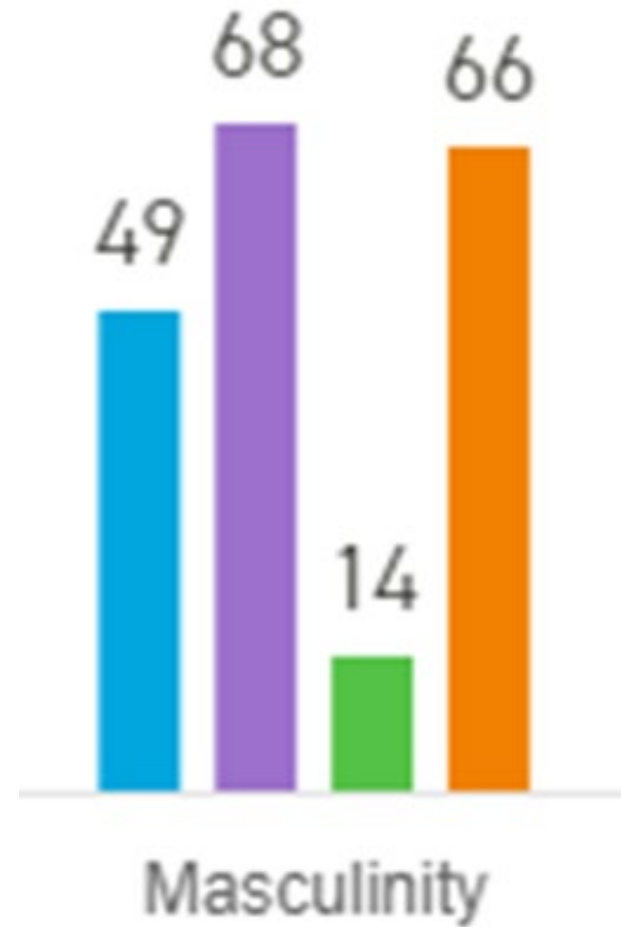
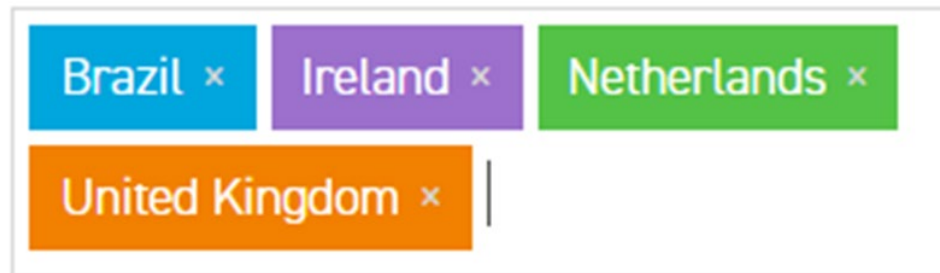
Feminine Societies

- Balance family and work
- Father and mother should both deal with facts and feelings
- Jealousy of high-flyers
- Sympathy for the weak
- Boys and girls may cry but neither should fight
- Religion focuses on fellow human beings

Masculine Societies

- Work prevails over family
- Father should deal with facts, mother with feelings
- Admiration for the strong
- Disdain of the weak
- Girls cry, boys don't; boys fight, girls shouldn't
- Religion focuses on powerful God or gods

scores close to 0 stand for the most feminine, scores close to 100 for the most masculine society



IS A SOCIETY DESCRIBED AS 'MASCULINE' OR 'FEMININE' IF IT STANDS FOR A PREFERENCE FOR COOPERATION, MODESTY, CARING FOR THE WEAK AND QUALITY OF LIFE?

1. Masculine

0%



2. Feminine

84.62%

3. Neither of the above

15.38%

4. UNCERTAINTY AVOIDANCE INDEX

Refers to the degree of comfort one has with ambiguous or risky situations, versus situations in which the outcome is assured (Hofstede, 1980; 2001)

The degree to which a society feels **threatened by uncertain, ambiguous or undefined situations.**

- In high uncertainty avoidance, people look for stable careers and tend to follow rules/procedures

The fundamental issue here is how a society deals with the fact that the future can never be known: ***should we try to control the future or just let it happen?***

- Countries exhibiting strong UAI maintain rigid codes of belief and behaviour, and are intolerant of unorthodox behaviour and ideas.
- Weak UAI societies maintain a more relaxed attitude in which there is tolerance towards opinions outside the norm



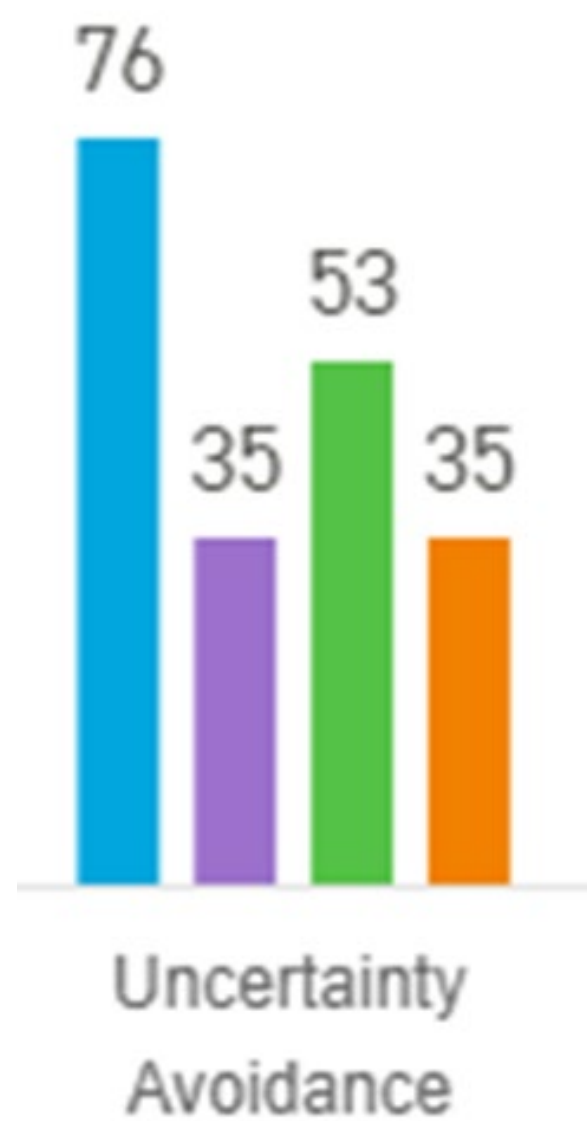
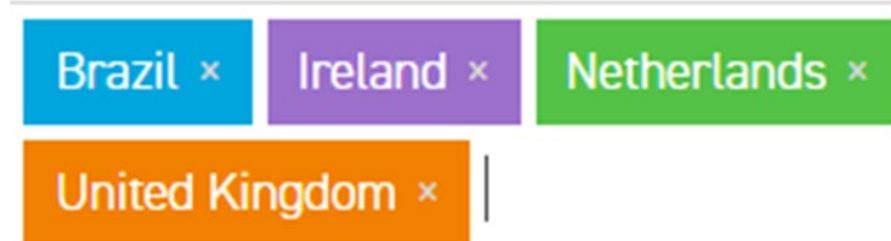
UNCERTAINTY AVOIDING SOCIETIES VERSUS UNCERTAINTY ACCEPTING SOCIETIES

Uncertainty Avoiding Societies

- The uncertainty inherent in life is a threat that must be fought
- High stress and anxiety
- Aggression and emotions may sometimes be vented
- What is different, is dangerous
- Need for rules, even if not practical and/or not practised
- Formalisation
- Adoption of innovations slow
- Staying in the same job
- Xenophobia

Uncertainty Accepting Societies

- Uncertainty is normal
- Low stress and anxiety
- Aggression and emotions should be controlled
- What is different, is curious
- Fewer rules, which may be broken if necessary
- Deregulation
- Adoption of innovations fast
- Changing jobs easily
- Tolerance



IF A SOCIETY FEATURES STRICT LAWS AND RULES, IS IT MORE LIKELY TO BE:



1. Uncertainty avoiding



83.33%

2. Uncertainty accepting



16.67%

5. LONG TERM ORIENTATION VERSUS SHORT TERM ORIENTATION

Coined by Hofstede in 1991, developed by Michael Bond & extended by Michael Minkov (Bulgarian Sociologist) in 2010

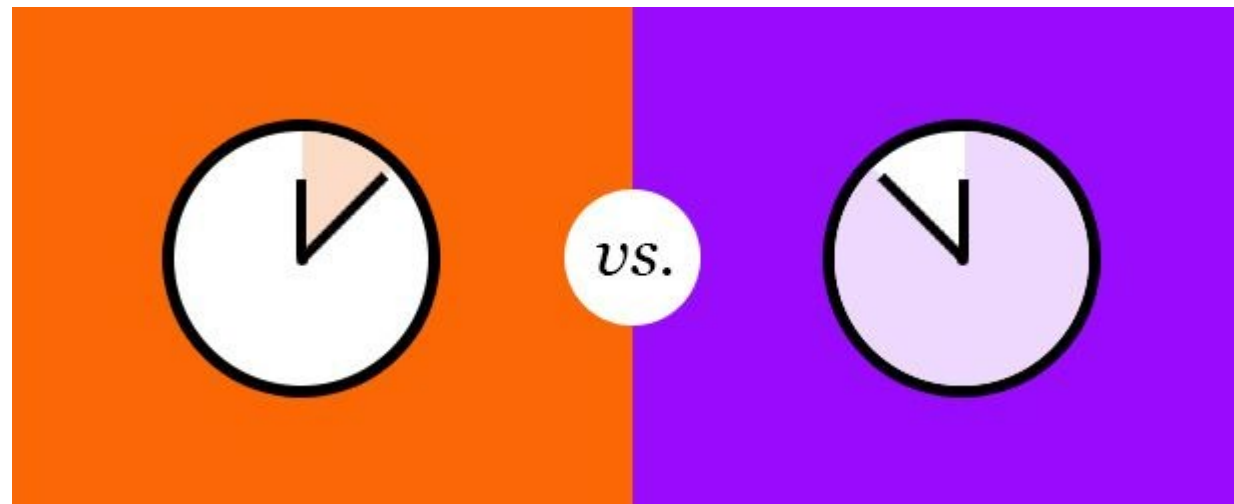
Refers to orientation towards savings, thrift & future plans, versus a need for immediate gratification (Hofstede, 2001)

Long-Term Orientation stands for the fostering in a society of pragmatic virtues oriented to future rewards, in particular perseverance, thrift, and adapting to changing circumstances

Its opposite pole, **Short-Term Orientation**, stands for the fostering in a society of virtues related to the past and the present, such as national pride, respect for tradition, and fulfilling social obligations

Societies who score low (i.e. have a short-term orientation) on this dimension, **prefer to maintain time-honoured traditions and norms** while viewing societal change with suspicion.

Those with a culture which scores high (i.e. those with a long-term orientation) take **a more pragmatic approach** - they encourage thrift and **efforts in modern education** as a way to prepare for the future.



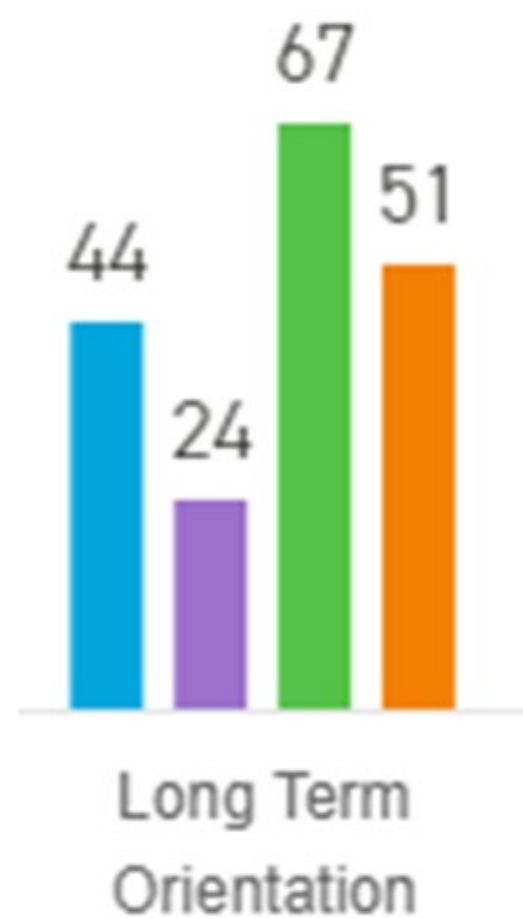
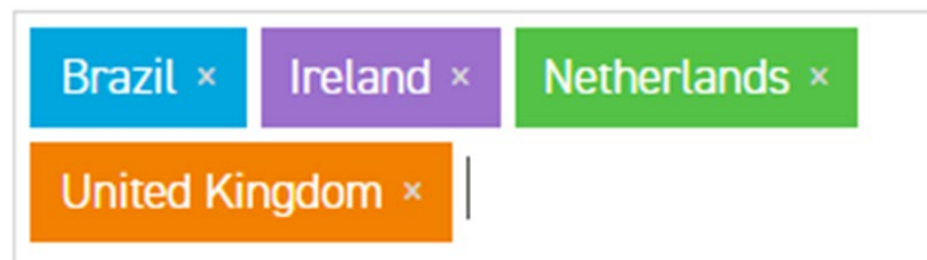
LONG-TERM ORIENTED SOCIETIES VERSUS SHORT-TERM ORIENTED SOCIETIES

Long-Term Oriented Societies

- Which norms apply depends on the situation
- The superior person adapts to the circumstances
- We want to learn from other countries
- Traditions can be changed
- Opposing truths can be integrated
- Common sense and choosing the middle way

Short-Term Oriented Societies

- Fixed norms apply always, whatever the circumstances
- The superior person is always the same
- We are proud of our own country
- Traditions are sacrosanct
- Truth A always excludes its opposite B
- Religious and ideological fundamentalisms



LONG-TERM ORIENTATION FOSTERS WHICH OF THE FOLLOWING:

1. Virtues related to the past and the present, such as national pride, respect for tradition, and fulfilling social obligations

 5.88%



2. Pragmatic virtues oriented to future rewards, in particular perseverance, thrift, and adapting to changing circumstances

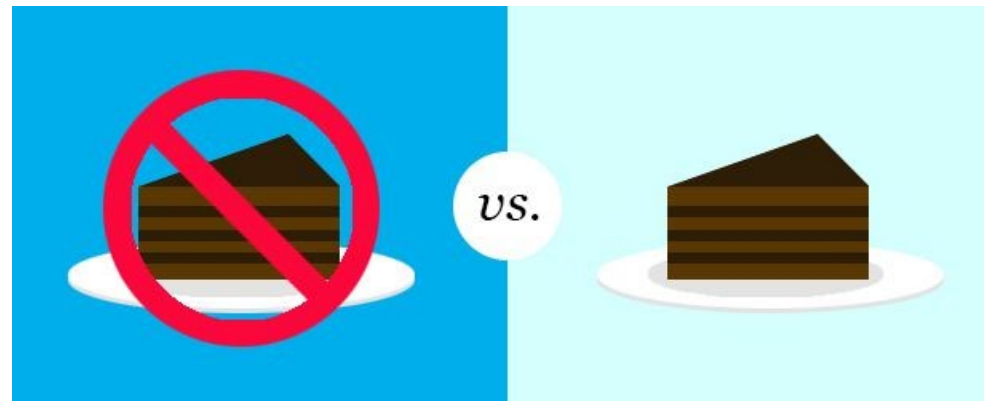
 94.12%

6. INDULGENCE VERSUS RESTRAINT

Indulgence stands for a society that allows **relatively free gratification of basic and natural human drives** related to enjoying life and having fun.

Restraint stands for a society that **suppresses gratification of needs** and regulates it by means of strict social norms

Introduced in 2010



- Coined by Michael Minkov (Bulgarian sociologist) for covering certain societal differences which were unexplained by Hofstede's other five dimensions
- Indulgent cultures place more importance on freedom of speech and personal control, while in restrained cultures there is a greater sense of helplessness about personal destiny
- Impact on workplace
 - likely to have an impact on how willing employees are to voice opinions and give feedback.
 - In cultures that are perceived as placing a greater importance on personal happiness and freedom, employees may be more likely to leave an organisation when they are not happy in their role.

INDULGENT SOCIETIES VERSUS RESTRAINED SOCIETIES

Indulgent Societies

- People feel healthier and happier
- A perception of personal life control
- Leisure ethic
- Optimism, positive attitude
- More extraverted personalities
- Having friends very important
- Active participation in sports
- Less moral discipline

Restrained societies

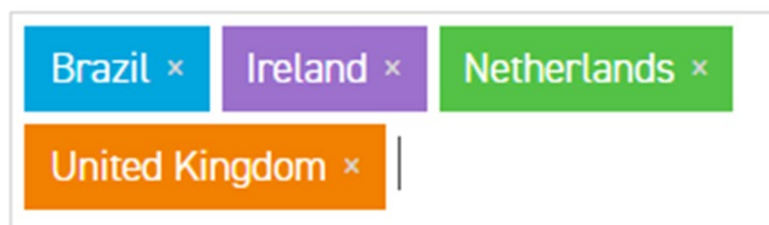
- People feel less happy and less healthy
- 'What happens to me is not my doing'
- Work ethic
- Pessimism, cynicism
- More introverted personalities
- Having friends less important
- Less sports participation
- Stricter moral discipline

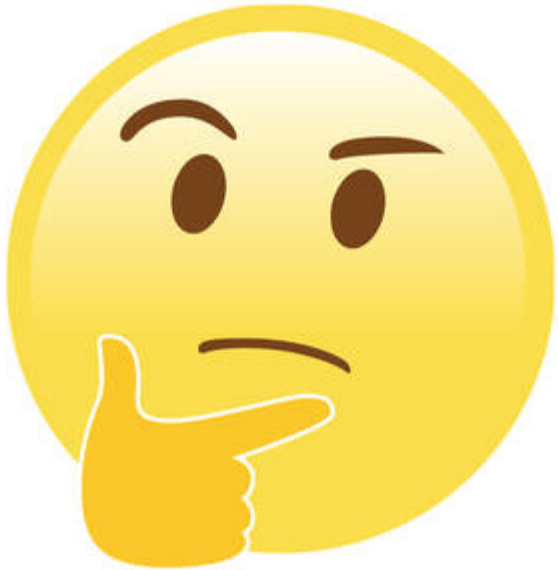
Indulgent

97 Mexico
84 Nigeria
78 Sweden
71 Australia
69 Britain
68 Netherlands
68 U.S.A.
59 Brazil

Restrained

48 France
42 Japan
40 Germany
30 Italy
26 India
24 China
20 Russia
04 Egypt





**Do you agree with
Hofstede's model?**

CRITIQUING HOFSTEDE'S CONTRIBUTION (MC SWEENEY, 2002)

Read McSweeney's (2002) article on Brightspace to understand some critiques of Hofstede's cultural dimensions

Some critiques mentioned:

1. Can surveys be used to 'measure' culture?
2. "Hofstede supposes that in IBM there is a singular, uniform and monopolistic organisational culture" (McSweeney, 2002, p.96)
3. The data was largely limited to respondents working in marketing/sales.
4. Assumptions of national uniformity – therefore it does not matter who within the nation is surveyed **because each member is assumed to have the same characteristics**

EXAM

Worth 60% of final grade for this module

5 questions, answer 3

All questions worth equal marks

Essay style answers – not bullet points

2 hours

Access exam timetable [here](#)

1st	2.1	2.2	Pass	Fail
Excellent structure; excellent grasp of topic, evaluation & synthesis.	Very good structure; strong analysis, solid grasp of topic.	Good structure – weak in parts. Satisfactory application of content with examples. Some discussion evident.	Recall/basic understanding of the question. Some attempt to link between question and content from lectures/reading. May be some bullet points.	Incomplete or confused understanding of topic. Inability to link content from lectures to question. Bullet points. Gaps
Evaluation & synthesis	Application & analysis	Understanding & application	Knowledge	Inadequate